M365-03 · Shared Mailbox Request, Provisioning & Ownership

How a departmental mailbox is requested, who owns it, who may be added to it, and when that access goes away.

Field	Value
Document ID	M365-03
Version	1.0 · Known Good edition, by Kevin Zelman
Catalogue domain	A. Microsoft 365
Operating tier	Tier 2 — Advanced Technical Services, which already owns permissions.
Review cycle	Annually.
Related existing policy	Your organization's email and account policy. This procedure operates under it and does not replace it.

1. Purpose

A shared mailbox lets a department receive and answer mail as the department rather than as a person, so that enquiries survive holidays, role changes and departures. This document says how one is obtained and, more importantly, who is answerable for it afterwards.

It exists because that second part is so often missing. The common version: a busy front-desk team adds several temporary workers to its departmental mailbox through a reply-all email thread. There is no named owner, no request record, and nothing scheduled to remove the access at the end of the engagement. Then the next department asks the same way.

> **The single change this document makes**
> Every shared mailbox has one named owner, and that owner approves every addition. IT provisions and administers; it does not decide who in a department should read the department's mail.
> Without an owner, IT is left inferring authorisation from whoever is on an email thread — which is not authorisation, and is not a position anybody should be put in.

2. Scope

- Shared mailboxes for departments, functions, roles and projects.
- Membership, delegation, send-as and send-on-behalf.

- Review, ownership transfer and closure. Out of scope: distribution lists and dynamic groups, which are M365-04 and are a different thing frequently asked for by the same words; personal mailbox delegation, which is ACC-14; Microsoft 365 group mailboxes created with a Team, which are M365-07.

3. What a shared mailbox is for, and what it is not

A shared mailbox is right when	Use something else when
A department needs one published address that several people answer — info@, billing@, servicedesk@.	You want to send mail to a group of people. That is a distribution list or dynamic group (M365-04).
Continuity matters more than individual attribution: the enquiry must be answerable if one person is away.	One person needs someone to manage their calendar or mail. That is delegation (ACC-14).
A role or function outlives the person holding it.	A team needs a workspace with files and chat. That is a Team (M365-07).
Mail must be retained with the function rather than in an individual's mailbox.	You want a login that several people share. Never. That defeats every audit (ACC-15).

The last row is worth stating plainly: a shared mailbox is not a shared account. Nobody signs in as the mailbox. Members sign in as themselves and the mailbox appears alongside their own — which is what preserves the audit trail.

4. Roles — the owner is the point of this document

Role	Responsible for
Mailbox owner (a named staff member, not IT)	Deciding who has access and approving every addition. Confirming at review that the membership is still right. Nominating a successor before they leave. The owner is a person, not a department — "Front desk" cannot approve anything.
Deputy owner (recommended)	Doing the above when the owner is unavailable. A mailbox whose only owner is on leave becomes an IT judgement call again.
Members	Answering the mail. Not adding other people.
Tier 2 — Account Services	Provisioning, adding and removing on the owner's written approval, and running the review.
Tier 4	Approving exceptions, and deciding ownership where a department cannot or will not nominate.

> **Why IT cannot be the owner**
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> IT is asked to be, frequently, because it is easier. But IT does not know which members of the front-desk team should read customer correspondence — that is the department's judgement, and the moment IT makes it, IT owns the consequences of getting it wrong.
>
> Where a department genuinely has nobody to name, that is a Tier 4 conversation with the department head rather than a default to IT.

5. Requesting one

1. The requester submits the fields in Appendix A through the service desk. Not by reply-all email thread — the whole point is that the authorisation is recorded somewhere it can be found later.
2. Tier 2 checks that the request names an owner who is a member of staff, and that the address does not already exist in some other form.
3. Where the request is really for a distribution list, Tier 2 says so and redirects to M365-04 rather than provisioning the wrong object. These are asked for interchangeably and the difference matters.
4. Where the mailbox will receive data of a sensitive class — customer records, payroll, health, conduct — the request is referred to Tier 4 before provisioning (M365-15).
5. Tier 2 provisions per §6 and confirms to the requester and the owner together, so the owner knows they are the owner. An owner who has not been told they are one is not one.

6. Provisioning

1. Create the mailbox with the agreed address. Naming follows the function, not the person or the current post-holder.
2. Set the owner and deputy in the mailbox's recorded metadata, and in the register IT keeps of mailboxes and owners. If that register does not exist yet, this document is the reason to start it.
3. Add the initial members the owner approved. No more.
4. Configure send-as for the members who need it (§8).
5. Confirm auditing is on, so that "who sent that" and "who read that" are answerable later.
6. Set the review date — twelve months, or end of the engagement where the membership includes temporary workers.
7. Record the request, the approval and the initial membership on the ticket.

7. Adding and removing people

7.1 Adding

- Only on the owner's written approval, on a ticket. A name in a reply-all thread is not an approval, and this is the specific practice being replaced.
- The person being added must have MFA registered first (ACC-03 §5.1).
- Temporary workers are added under ACC-09 and their access carries an end-date expiry, even if they stay on in another role. This is the control whose absence leaves grants with no owner.

- Access is to the mailbox, granted to the person's own identity — never by creating an account for the mailbox, and never by sharing a credential.

7.2 Removing

- On the owner's request; at the end of the engagement for temporary workers; automatically on the leaver procedure (ACC-01 §7.2); and at review where the membership is no longer justified.
- Removal does not need the owner's approval when it is triggered by a leaver or an engagement end date. Those are automatic, and waiting for an approval is how access persists.

7.3 When the owner leaves

Ownership transfers before their access is removed, not after. An unowned mailbox is how a departmental address quietly stops being answered — and the equivalent failure on SharePoint shows up as broken-links tickets nobody can assign. ACC-01 §7.2 step 4 makes this a leaver checklist item.

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8. Sending as the department

Two mechanisms, and the difference is visible to recipients:

Permission	What the recipient sees
Send as	The message appears to come from the department. Use this as the default — a customer writing to info@ should hear back from the department.
Send on behalf of	The message shows " on behalf of ". Use where individual attribution is wanted, for example in conduct or complaint correspondence.

Either way, the mailbox audit log records which member actually sent it. That is what makes send-as safe, and it is also the answer to a concern raised in ACC-02: departmental mail can read as the department without giving anybody a second identity.

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9. Review and closure

1. At the review date, Tier 2 sends the owner the current membership and asks them to confirm or correct it. A non-response is chased once, then escalated to the owner's manager — never treated as approval.
2. Temporary-worker membership is removed at the end of the engagement and re-added on fresh approval, rather than confirmed in place. Re-approval is a decision; confirmation is a habit.
3. Where a mailbox has received no mail in twelve months and the owner agrees it is dormant, close it: convert to inactive with retention per ACC-01 §7.3, remove members, and record the closure. Do not delete — a published address that starts bouncing is worse than one that is quietly monitored.
4. Where a mailbox has no identifiable owner at review, it goes to Tier 4 as a decision, not to IT as a default.

10. Service levels

Request	Commitment (per GOV-06)
New shared mailbox, complete request	P3 — acknowledged within 1 coverage day.
Add or remove a member, owner-approved	P3 — acknowledged within 1 coverage day; usually same day.
Add a member where MFA is not yet registered	Held. The requester is told what is needed rather than the request being provisioned anyway.
Sensitive-class mailbox needing Tier 4 referral	P3, with the Tier 4 decision inside 5 coverage days.
Ownership transfer on a leaver	Follows ACC-01 §7 timing — completed before the leaver's access is removed.

11. Records

Record	Held in	Retention
Register of mailboxes, owners and deputies	IT register	Live document
Request, with owner approval	Ticket	3 years
Every addition and removal, with who approved it	Ticket	3 years
Annual review confirmations	Ticket	3 years
Closure decisions	Ticket + register	3 years

12. Related documents

ID	Title	Relationship
Email & Account Policy	Your organization's email and account policy	The existing policy this procedure operates under.
M365-04	Distribution List & Dynamic Group Standard	The thing people frequently mean when they ask for a shared mailbox.
M365-05	Email Alias & Address Change Standard	An alias is often the cheaper answer to "we need a new address".
M365-15	Data Classification & Handling	Determines whether §5 step 4 applies.
ACC-01	Account Lifecycle	§7.2 step 4 reassigns ownership on departure.
ACC-02	Account Naming Standard	§8 send-as is central to the Option B case.
ACC-09	Temporary Worker & Departmental Access	End-of-engagement expiry for temporary-worker membership.

ID	Title	Relationship
ACC-14	Mailbox & Calendar Delegation Standard	The other thing this is confused with.
ACC-17	Periodic Access Review	Consumes the §9 review.
GOV-06	Service Commitments, Priority & Escalation	Supplies §10.

Appendix A — Request form fields

Field	Why
Requested address	Function-based, not person-based.
Purpose, in one sentence	Distinguishes a mailbox from a distribution list at the point of request.
Named owner (staff member)	The whole point. A department name is not an owner.
Named deputy owner	So the mailbox does not become an IT judgement call during annual leave.
Initial members	Each named individually.
Any temporary workers among them?	Triggers the end-date expiry in §7.1.
Does it receive sensitive data?	Customer records, payroll, health, conduct — triggers the §5 step 4 referral.
Send-as or send-on-behalf?	Default is send-as; §8 explains the difference.

Appendix B — Owner’s one-pager

Send this to every new mailbox owner. Most owners do not know they have become one.

You now own a mailbox	You are the person who decides who can read and answer mail sent to this address. IT will administer it, but will not add anybody without your say-so.
To add somebody	Ask the service desk, naming the person. Please do it that way rather than by email thread — it means there is a record of who authorised it, which protects you as much as anyone.
Temporary workers	Their access ends automatically at the end of the engagement. If you want it to continue, you will be asked to approve it again — that is deliberate.
Once a year	We will send you the list of people who have access and ask you to confirm it is still right. It takes a minute and it is the main thing that stops access accumulating.
Before you leave or change role	Please tell us who should take over. A mailbox with no owner stops being answered, and nobody notices until an enquirer complains.
What recipients see	By default, replies appear to come from the department rather than from you personally. We can change that if you would rather.

Part of the Known Good SOP Catalog by Kevin Zelman, written for small IT shops, contractors and consultants, career-changers and help desk technicians. Adapt the names, tiers and times to your own shop: the times here are cushion, not a promise.